MISSISSIPPI

The Magnolia State



The Mississippi River has always had a personality—wide, dark, and unhurried, carrying the silt and soil of half a continent southward toward the Gulf. It was that river mud, rich and deep chocolate brown, that gave the state's most beloved dessert its name. And like the river itself, Mississippi Mud Pie carries the history of everyone who ever lived along its banks.

The roots of this dish reach deep into the antebellum South, where enslaved Black women ran the plantation kitchens of the Mississippi Delta with extraordinary skill and little recognition. They worked with what the land and the larder offered—dark molasses, cracked pecans, farm eggs, and whatever chocolate could be traded or purchased in towns like Natchez and Vicksburg. From these kitchens came a tradition of dense, fudgy, unapologetically rich baking that would outlast the world that tried to contain it. The flavors they built—bittersweet, nutty, almost smoky at the edges—are the direct ancestors of what fills a mud pie today.

After the Civil War, Vicksburg emerged as a vital commercial hub along the river, its bluffs lined with merchants, steamboat traffic, and the slow rebuilding of Southern life. It was in towns like these, in church fellowship halls and home kitchens, that community baking culture flourished. Women gathered to cook for funerals, harvests, and celebrations, trading recipes across back fences and Sunday tables. Chocolate, once a luxury, became increasingly available through Mississippi River trade routes by the late 19th century, and bakers wasted no time putting it to work in the deep, brownie-like confections the Delta was already known for.

The name "Mississippi Mud" is believed to have emerged sometime in the mid-20th century, a nod to the dark, cracked surface of the finished dessert—the way it settles and splits as it cools, resembling nothing so much as the sun-baked riverbank mud that lines the Mississippi on a dry August afternoon in Greenville or Clarksdale. It was humble, proud, and exactly right. The comparison stuck because anyone who has ever stood on the banks of that river and looked down at its dark, layered earth immediately understands what they are about to taste.

This is a dessert that rewards you generously. The moment you pull it from the oven—dense and fudgy at the center, crusted at the edges, fragrant with chocolate and toasted pecans—you will understand why Mississippi claims it so fiercely. Serve it warm with a spoonful of vanilla ice cream melting into the cracks, and you won't just be making dessert. You'll be sitting down at a table with generations of the South's most gifted, resilient, and delicious culinary history.

MUD PIE

Few things in this world speak to the soul quite like a slice of Mississippi Mud Pie—that gloriously fudgy, crumbling-edged, pecan-studded slab of Southern joy that turns any ordinary table into a celebration.

Yield: 10–12 servings

INGREDIENTS

CRUST

- 2 cups chocolate wafer cookies or chocolate graham crackers, finely crushed
- ½ cup unsalted butter, melted
- 2 Tbsp granulated sugar

FUDGE LAYER

- 1 cup semisweet chocolate chips
- ½ cup unsalted butter
- ¾ cup granulated sugar
- 2 large eggs, lightly beaten
- 2 Tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ¼ tsp salt

CHOCOLATE PUDDING LAYER

- ½ cup granulated sugar
- ¼ cup cornstarch
- ¼ cup unsweetened cocoa powder
- ¼ tsp salt
- 2 ½ cups whole milk
- 3 large egg yolks, lightly beaten
- 4 oz. semisweet chocolate, chopped
- 2 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

WHIPPED CREAM TOPPING

- 1 ½ cups heavy cream, cold
- 3 Tbsp powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Chocolate curls or shavings, chopped toasted pecans, or mini marshmallows or a drizzle of chocolate sauce, for garnish (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the Crust*: Preheat oven to 350°F (175°C). Mix the crushed wafers, melted butter, and sugar until evenly moistened. Press into the bottom and sides of a 9-inch deep-dish pie pan. Bake for 8–10 minutes until set. Cool completely.
2. *Make the Fudge Layer*: In a saucepan over low heat, melt chocolate chips and butter, stirring until smooth. Whisk in sugar, then remove from heat and whisk in eggs quickly (so they don't scramble). Stir in cocoa, vanilla, and salt until glossy. Spread evenly over cooled crust. Bake 15 minutes at 350°F (175°C), until just set but slightly gooey in the center. Cool.

3. *Make the Chocolate Pudding Layer*: In a saucepan, whisk sugar, cornstarch, cocoa, and salt. Slowly whisk in milk until smooth. Cook over medium heat, whisking constantly, until thickened and bubbling. Temper egg yolks by whisking in a little hot mixture, then return yolks to the pan. Cook 1 minute more. Remove from heat, stir in chopped chocolate, butter, and vanilla until smooth. Pour pudding over fudge layer. Cover with plastic wrap (touching surface to prevent skin) and chill at least 3 hours until firm.
4. *Make the Whipped Cream Topping*: Beat cream, powdered sugar, and vanilla until soft peaks form. Spread generously over the chilled pie.
5. *Garnish & Serve*: Top with chocolate curls, toasted pecans, or marshmallows if desired. Slice and serve chilled but not icy cold, so the layers soften slightly.

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Mud Pie — finished dish illustration — full-page spread, left page

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Mud Pie — finished dish illustration — full-page spread, right page

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people